

CHINESE TEA CULTURE

Tea has been highly valued in Chinese life for thousands of years. Through the centuries, the culture and customs surrounding tea evolved into an art form. To the Chinese, tea was not only a tonic and medicine, it also had the ability to inspire creativity.

THE ANCIENT PAST

For over 4,000 years, tea was cultivated and consumed only in China. Then, after trade started along the Silk Road and Tea Horse Road (named after the main goods sold on these roads), areas near the Chinese border were introduced to tea. Although tea drinking had been part of Chinese life since the Han dynasty (206BCE–220CE), it was only under the Tang and Song dynasties (618–907CE and 960–1279CE) that elaborate ceremonies, such as Gongfu Cha (see pp78–83), came into practice. Lu Yu, a Tang dynasty scholar wrote a book called *Cha Ching* (The Classic of Tea). This detailed guide to tea planting, harvesting, and preparation was a turning point in tea history and was responsible for tea achieving cultural status in Chinese life.

TEA HOUSES

Beginning in the Tang dynasty, people of all classes gathered at “tea houses,” which sold tea and refreshments, to discuss recent events and to socialize. They were often set on or near water, so that patrons could watch koi fish swimming beneath them and listen to the running water, which added to the beauty of the whole experience.

Tea houses became centers of social life where art was displayed, poetry, music, and calligraphy enjoyed, and even plays staged. During the Qing dynasty (1644–1912CE), operas depicting aspects of life in the tea hills became popular and were performed regularly. One of these, the Gannan Tea Picking Opera of Jiangxi province, has been performed for more than 300 years, and features songs sung by tea pickers in the fields to pass the time.



BRICK TEA

Compressing tea leaves into bricks, like this one, made them less susceptible to physical damage along trade routes.

BAMBOO CASES

In ancient China, tea leaves were often encased in bamboo to protect the tea on long journeys along the tea-trading routes.

